

CHAPTER 7

FEMINIST THEORY AND ORGANIZATION THEORY: A DIALOGUE ON NEW BASES

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Is 'GENDER' still an issue in social and organizational sciences? And, if it is, does it concern only bodily difference, discrimination practices, and organizations as reproducing inequality?

Many scholars argue that nowadays 'gender' has lost its importance. A well-known critic of modernity writes: 'As anatomy stops being destiny, sexual identity more and more becomes a life-style issue' (Giddens 1992: 199). The consequences of accepting the definition of sexual identity as gender and gender as a lifestyle are that gender is again relegated to the private, organizations regain innocence, and the micropolitics of organization life are obscured. This representation of gender will be contrasted with the argument that the changing social and historical meaning of 'gender' is destabilizing its interpretative categories, bringing to the fore the plurality of differences (not only those related to gender) and, together with the appearance of multiple voices, the claim to multiple knowledges.

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Gender has to do not only with bodies, and power, but also with the politics of knowledge, and therefore with organizations as containers of different bodies and sexualities, as arenas of power/knowledge, and with organization theory as a system of knowledge representation.

The contention that the organizational knowledge conventionally called ‘organizational theory’ (OT) is male gendered is too well known to reiterate. The pun that renders the ‘mainstream’ as the ‘malestream’ expresses an awareness that has no need of elaboration. It is less well known, however, that the dialogue that has taken place since the 1970s between critical reflections on gender—what I shall call ‘feminist theory’ (FT)—and OT has involved numerous voices and has enriched both areas of thought.

In this article I start from the premises that neither FT nor OT is a homogeneous and unitary body of knowledge, my intention being to illustrate the multiple points of view expressed by those involved in this conversation, and to outline current developments within it. I shall argue that the theoretical interests of OT and FT may converge on a research programme centred on the politics of knowledge. In developing this thesis, I shall briefly survey the main theories in gender studies, showing how they represent the relation between gender and organization and contribute to analysis of organizations and organizational processes. I conclude with a reflection on the politics of knowledge in FT and OT and the—ironic, nomadic, eccentric—knowing subjects.

7.1 GENDER AS A SITUATED CATEGORY OF ANALYSIS

In my experience as a sociologist, teacher, and feminist,¹ when I introduce students to the concepts of ‘socially constructed reality’, and ‘reflexivity’, I always use the example of ‘gender’ as a category invented by feminists at the end of the 1970s. I do so because it is a useful device to illustrate, in a cultural and historical perspective, how social categorization has given form, substance, and visibility to women’s experiences. But did not women and their experiences exist before the word ‘gender’? And do they not continue to exist outside its semantic domain? Answering these questions is a complex task requiring intricate argument to demonstrate that

¹ The use of the first person singular, as well as the personal references, are not accidental. They result from a deliberate rhetorical intent to criticize the ‘scientific’ style of writing that produces authoritativeness by cancelling the subject and producing dis-embodied texts. On this see, Silverman (1993); Jacques (1997).

the category of gender has given visibility to, and thereby enabled the investigation of, a social reality that was previously 'non-existent' because it was not part of theoretical awareness. The use of the category has given rise to a political subject—a feminist movement—able to conduct autonomous reflection on the conditions of its own existence, and also a critique of what counts as 'knowledge' and how the 'knower' is constructed. Moreover, by generating new knowledge, it has also modified gender relationships. The meaning of the term 'gender' is a social product that changes through the use that a society makes of it and the knowledge that it produces.

In the arbitrary way in which all histories use a point of departure and a founding myth to ground themselves in History, we may follow Piccone Stella and Saraceno (1996) by adopting the convention that the term 'gender' made its first official appearance in scientific discourse in 1975. That was the year when Gayle Rubin, in her book *The Traffic in Women*, used the expression 'sex-gender system' to denote the set of processes, adaptations, patterns of behaviour, and relationships by which every society transforms biological sexuality into products of human activity.

The term 'gender' thus first arose in the academic studies of American feminism (Nicholson 1994). It was then imported into Europe with different outcomes but a shared endeavour in social studies. In fact, the evocative connotation implicit in the term 'gender' arises from the act of classification and the social act of seeing human beings as two, and only two, types of individuals. Gender is therefore a binary concept: men and women constitute gender; or in other words, the ways in which human beings present themselves, self-represent themselves, and are perceived in society constitute gender. In this sense, gender is a relational concept subsumed by a dyadic code that entails constant relation and tension. As a consequence, by exploring the relationships between men and women gender studies modify the concept of gender, defer its historical meaning, and thereby open the way for a plurality of interpretations of what constitutes 'gender'.

Not only should the singular and universal Man give way to the diversity of social experiences in their duality, but scientific categories should change to include this plurality of interpretations. A telling example is provided by Chiara Saraceno (1993) when she points out that if the extension of economic analysis to women's work has uncovered a presence that was previously neglected, this should lead not to sectorial analysis 'of women' but rather to a redefinition of the term 'labour force', and to critical reflection on the measurement of market value. The same example can be set within organizational studies: what is required is not study of participation by women in organizational processes, but rather a redefining of 'organizational categories' so that they explicitly accommodate the experiences of men and women and reveal the ideological consequences of representing an abstract 'labour force' and a de-sexualized and dis-embodied worker in language.

It is an irony of history that it is women who have coined the term 'gender' to denote and give voice to a knowledge grounded in different experiences and

situated in possession of a different body, and that many scholars (men and women) have interpreted gender studies as involving the study 'of women', as if only they possessed a body and a gender. The alleged gender neutrality of the term 'labour force' covers its masculinity, and the use of the term 'gender' to refer to women shows that in fact women are not allowed *not* to have a body, and therefore a bodily-situated knowledge. The equations 'sex = gender' and 'gender = women' are not only misunderstandings due to inexperience or to a linguistic operation which attenuates the social embarrassment caused by the word 'sex', replacing it with a more 'polite' one; they are an ideological operation which allows gender studies to continue without calling the gender relation—that is, the relation between the male and female, men and women, masculine and feminine—into question. In this manner, maleness is made invisible, removed from critical reflection and continues to be the prime term, the one in relation to which the other is defined by default.

Formulation of the concept of gender imports two simultaneously evoked differences into OT: sexual differences and power differences. Put briefly, one may say that the concept has affected organizational analysis by prompting study of the extent to which sexual difference is socially and organizationally constructed, and of the extent to which gender relations spring from other than biological differences between men and women. In order to explore whether and to what extent the transformative impact of the category 'gender' has been realized in OT, one must retrace the debate on gender within feminist studies. This will clarify that the concept of gender is not immutable, that it has indeed undergone rapid changes, and that different research programmes in the intersection of gender and organizations are based on different conceptions of gender.

7.2 WHEREIN DOES GENDER DIFFERENCE LIE?

Analysis of sexual difference has identified the subjectivity of a political actor which addresses the question 'What is a woman?' and comes up with three answers, locating the origin of the difference in:

1. *The body*, as the biological basis of both sexuality and the capacity of women to bear children. This is the essentialist position that views the maternal body as defining the qualities of women: nurturance, a capacity for intimacy, and pacifism. The woman/mother relationship also generates the mental mechanisms of early infancy that differentiate a child's first social relationships by gender (Chodorow 1978). However much gender may be socially constructed, according to this

approach, it is the body that constitutes the biological material for the differentiation between female or male.

2. *Society, culture, or politics*, this being the position that European debate has labelled 'culturalist' in order to emphasize the social construction of gender, and also to stress that the social construction of a person's 'nature' is a social and organizational process which attributes gender and constructs biology (Lorber and Farrell 1991). In the Anglo-American debate, the term 'culturalist' is used to refer not so much to the nature/culture dichotomy as to a 'female culture' elaborated on biological difference. French and Italian feminism view the body as the symbolic rather than the physical origin of the subject 'woman' (Irigaray 1974; Cavarero 1990; Muraro 1991). This subject is unable to 'auto-signify herself' because western philosophical thought has imposed itself as male thought, devising a universal and neutral subject that defines and represents the world in its own terms. As a consequence, women have been denied access to the symbolic.

3. *Language*. According to deconstructionist and post-structuralist analysis, western logocentric thought has produced individuals shaped by discursive practices. Deconstructionism is therefore a feminist practice that encourages women to show that the practices which define them are a fiction and are historically situated in power relations. Post-structuralist feminism and the postmodern debate on contemporary subjectivity emphasize that the crisis of subjectivity mainly affects the western male, while 'other' subjectivities are now moving to centre stage (Flax 1987; Hekman 1990).

These three sources of differentiation—body, society, and language—are understood differently according to a plurality of approaches in the conversation between FT and OT as well. In order to provide a historical overview of feminist approaches, and of how they have regarded organizational studies, I shall refer to the survey of the literature conducted by Marta Calás and Linda Smircich (1996).² Table 7.1 is an extreme simplification of their analysis, its sole purpose being to highlight: (i) how the various conceptions of the sex-gender system translate into different conceptions of the relation between gender and organizational studies, (ii) how epistemological mingling in the social sciences has benefited from the feminist critique, and (iii) how the latter has completed a cycle of dissemination by moving, so to speak, from women's studies to gender studies.

² Calás and Smircich's classification of feminist theories is based on an Anglo-American understanding of political categories and feminist historical movements. These categories partly overlap with the European understanding of politics and feminist thought, and partly do not represent them. My reason for not giving an Eurocentric interpretation of feminist theories lays in recognition that there is an Anglo-American hegemony within OT as well, and keeping the two stories together makes it easier for the reader to follow the line of argument. In writing for an international audience I adhere to the fiction of a single (but not universal) body of knowledge called OT, but am well aware of the political nature of such a representation.

Table 7.1 A summary of feminist approaches

School of thought	Liberal	Radical	Psychoanalytic	Marxist	Socialist	Poststructuralist/ Postmodern	Third World/ Post-colonial
Intellectual roots	Evolved from 18th and 19th century political economy	Generated in the women's liberation movements of the late 1960s	Evolved from Freudian and other psychoanalytic theories, in particular object-relations theories	Based on, and a 'correction' of, the Marxist critique of capitalist society since the mid-19th century	Emerged in the 1970s as part of attempts by women's liberation movements to synthesize Marxist, psychoanalytic, and radical feminisms	Located in contemporary French poststructuralist critiques of 'knowledge' and 'identity'	Emerging from intersections of gendered critiques of western feminisms and post-colonial critiques of western epistemologies
Conception of sex/ gender	Sex is part of the essential biological endowment, a binary variable Gender is socialized onto sexed human beings for appropriate behaviour	'Sex class' is the condition of women as an oppressed class Gender is a social construction that ensures women's subordination to men	Individuals become sexually identified as part of their psychosexual development Gender structures a social system of male domination that influences psychosexual development	Gender is part of historical class relations that constitute systems of oppression under capitalism	Gender is processual and is socially constituted through several intersections of sex, race, ideology, and experiences of oppression under patriarchy and capitalism (which are distinct systems)	Sex/gender are discursive practices that constitute specific subjectivities through power and resistance in the materiality of human bodies	Considers the constitution of complex subjectivities beyond western conceptions of sex/gender, focusing on gendered aspects of globalization processes
Representation of gender/ organization	Organization theory as gender neutral	Alternative feminist organizing practices	Female skills as an organizational advantage	Organizations as sites of reproduction of patriarchy and capitalism	Organizing as gendered processes	Organizing as the discursive mobilization of power/knowledge resources	Globalized economy and worldwide organizing principles

Source: Calás and Smircich 1996 (first and second row), my integration (third row).

Following Calás and Smircich's description of how various feminist approaches intersect with organizational studies, different 'voices' join in a metaphorical conversation (see Table 7.1):

- *Liberal feminist theory.* Following liberal political theorists of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, the issue of equal access with men to opportunities in all spheres of life, but without radical transformation of the social and political system, arose in the 1960s, the aim being to achieve equal representation, to fight sex discrimination, and to deny sex differences. Liberal feminists shifted from themes of equality to themes of difference in the 1980s and 1990s, still pursuing the issue of gender justice, while in organizational studies liberal feminist research favoured positivist epistemologies assumed to be gender-neutral. In the same vein organizational theory is based on the assumption of neutrality, and the organizational processes affected by gender stereotypes are viewed as merely 'reflecting' the wider social arrangements between the sexes. In the Anglo-Saxon organizational literature the strand of research which investigates gender equity has been labelled 'women-in-management' and seeks to demonstrate that women are as good as men in fulfilling organizational needs. A representative topic of this scholarship is the concept of 'glass ceiling', which addresses the persistence of sex segregation and tries to elucidate its causes through measurable constructs.
- *Radical feminist theory* takes the subordination of women as its fundamental problematic and has political roots in the new left (in the United States and in the 1968 student movements in Europe). It conceives gender as a system of male domination, a fundamental organizing principle of patriarchal society. Every sphere of life is an arena for sexual politics, because there is no distinction between the 'political' and 'personal' realms. The consciousness raising and separatism that developed as practice-located methods to shed light on women experiences and feminism are thought of as theory and practice of women and among women only. A separatist politics has been theorized in relation to male-dominated organizations in pursuit of alternative organizations that reflect feminist values and are 'leaderless' and 'structureless'. Feminist organizational practices should be informed by equality, community, participation, an integration of form and content (Brown 1991) and should always ask the woman question (Ferree and Martin 1995). Starting from a women-centred theory, some scholars have revised basic organizational concepts such as work, career, and management (Marshall 1984; Tancred 1995).
- *Psychoanalytic feminist theory* denies the biological determinism of traditional psychoanalytic interpretations of gender and sexuality, while considering the patriarchal family engendering distinctions in male/female psychological development and different notions of gendered self and identity. This is not only a

problem of socialization but also an epistemological one concerning whose knowledge is valued and whose is devalued (Braidotti 1989). Different psychosexual developments lead to different concepts of justice and morality: male morality is an ethics of justice, while female morality is an ethics of care (Gilligan 1982). By valuing the consequences of different psychosexual developments, organization theory finds explanations for women's fear of success, for female behaviours that are passive, ambivalent towards a career, which fall short in corporate (male) culture and treat women's difference as an advantage for corporate effectiveness: the female resource. Women's ways of knowing and leading, their relational skills, sensitivity, and empathy become skilled resources for global competition.

- *Marxist feminist theory* conceptualizes gender and identity as structural, historical, and material. As with class, gender subsumes women's relation to men under the workers' relation to capital. Marxist feminism analyses how identities are constructed through social practices such as work (and workplace-household intersection) by focusing on relations of inequality, power, patriarchy, and capitalism. It is concerned with the gendered division of labour and women's 'double' oppression by class and sex, capitalism and patriarchy (Hartsock 1983).
- *Socialist feminist theory*. In explaining the persistence of gender segregation and oppression, socialist feminism addresses complex intersections of gender, race, class, and sexuality. 'From equality to differences' was the slogan in Europe that led feminist movements in the 1980s to discover not only differences between men and women but also differences among women and the oppression of women by women. In the United States the influence of other social movements like the black or the sexual liberation movement was more direct and the confrontation more sharp. In both cases the result was deeper awareness that the lines of differentiation are not parallel, but intersect in multiple ways and are expressed in multiple voices. In organization theory, awareness grew that gender assumptions are embedded in societal expectations and that they interact with organizational rules and practices lying 'underneath' macro-social structural arrangements (Acker 1990, 1992). The gendering and racializing of organizations also occurs through symbols, images, ideologies that legitimize gender inequalities and differences. The structuring of organizations along gender lines also involves sexuality (Game and Pringle 1984) and organizational sexuality (Hearn and Parkin 1987).
- *Post-structuralist/postmodern feminist theory*. Postmodernism exhibits a critical distrust concerning 'meta-narratives', transcendental reason, and the possibility of objective knowledge, and with the same attitude post-structuralist feminist theory interrogates the constitution of the 'feminine' within modernity. French

feminism (Cixous and Clément 1986) and Anglo-American feminism (Weedon 1987) question the claims of many feminist theories which posit a privileged knowing subject, an essential feminine and universal representation of woman. This approach contains the basis for a broader critique of how 'knowledge' is constructed, in so far as it depends on the possibility of representing a reality that does not exist outside its representation in language. It is through language that researchers constitute the subject of their knowing, their subjectivities as knowers, and what counts as knowledge as distinct from what is 'not knowledge', i.e. the 'other' in the discourse, the silenced term. The precarious position of any claim to knowledge opens spaces for a distinctive feminist politics of knowledge that points to the local operation of power and the crucial role of discourse in sustaining hegemonic power. Using the metaphor of 'rewriting' (as an activity intended to expose the apparently unimpeachable structures of truth and knowledge) the works of Calás and Smircich (1992a, b) have been highly influential in focusing on the construction of gender in organizations and the involvement of organization studies as a scientific discipline in the constitution of gendered arrangements.

- *Third World/Post-colonial feminist theory.* Following rediscovery of Frantz Fanon (1952), post-colonial studies and an epistemological critique of western thought have acquired a new voice. The fragility of the category of gender is all the more evident when one considers the specificities of Third World women constituted as 'others' by western knowledges and First World women. In the context of specific First World/Third World relationships, a new subject acquires autonomy in self-signification under the new colonialism represented by globalization. Notions such as hybridization (Bhabha 1988) or *métissage* (Gruzinski 1999) express forms of assimilation and resistance to the dominant culture. In its reading of organizational phenomena such as globalization and transnationalization, the 'women-in-development' literature problematizes the representational space available for Third World women's subjectivities.

Feminism is a discourse on gender, but many different voices exist internally to it. Feminist theories have stressed the constitution of gender, locating it mainly in the body (liberal, radical, and psychoanalytic), in culture and social relations (Marxist, socialist, and post-colonial), and in language (post-structuralist). This brief excursus reveals crucial patterns in feminist thought that are also reflected in research on gender and in OT.

Although the category of gender has been decentralized, and although a web of signification is taking the place of a binary concept, gender is still linked to difference, inequality, and micro-politics of power. In the conversation between different feminisms a new awareness of the category 'gender' emerges in the intersections between bodies, discourses, and practices.

7.3 GENDER IN THE INTERSECTIONS BETWEEN BODIES, DISCOURSES, AND PRACTICES

To continue with the metaphor of science as conversation, I want to stress that some sort of agreement—always partial and unstable—has been reached on certain premisses from which the conversation may follow a different course. For example, certain arguments have reached a temporary closure in feminist approaches,³ and this has also happened in the relationship between FT and OT. In order to delineate how the theoretical interests of OT and FT may converge on a research programme centred on the politics of knowledge, I recall the turning points of several conversations that, in my opinion, have already expressed their potentiality.

The emancipationism which sought to deny gender difference or to posit the substantial extraneousness of women from organizations not based on female thought is a cycle of analysis that has for the moment come to a closure. In organizational studies, it is a cycle represented by the shift from the labelling of the gender/organization relationship as a 'neglected area' (Hearn and Parkin 1983; Mills 1988) to a frenetic endeavour to 'add women in' by both counting them and giving them recipes 'to fit into the organization'.

A second cycle of thought has sought to found a political subjectivity for women. The effect of this project for political action has been to emphasize the homogeneity of women rather than their differences. The latter have been set in relation to the 'other' subject, so that the differences among women and those among men are undervalued. The articulation of gender in relation to class and race has led to the pluralization of subjectivity. In organizational studies, this shift has taken the form of a transition from equality to difference, and it is particularly evident in studies on management and human resources policies. Through the pursuit of equal opportunities and by 'mainstreaming the gender agenda' (defined in the EU as 'feminizing the mainstream'), the claim that OT is gender-neutral has given way to the definition of the female as a 'resource' at the disposal of organizations. The categorization of the female workforce as a newly discovered resource for organizations sustains the discourse on affirmative actions while the valorization of the female becomes an ideological attack on forms of hegemonic masculinity that nowadays are dysfunctional to forms of organization such as 'the flat organization', teamwork, couching leadership, and similar. The apparent valorization of the

³ Pinch and Bijker (1989) use the term 'closure' for the political process of temporary stabilization of an artefact. They distinguish between a rhetorical closure and a closure by problem redefinition. In my opinion, also linguistic artefacts—theories—undergo the same stabilization process.

female as an organizational resource is another ideological device to co-opt white women by means of 'organizational seduction', using women's commitment, pleasure in work, and affirmation desires as means of organizational control.

Equal opportunities programmes and discourses turn the concern for the persistence of inequalities into a normative model that imposes inclusion at all costs on women. The diversity policies now arriving in Europe from the United States have been criticized (Lorbiecki and Jack 2000) as perpetuating rather than combating inequality and as prescribing essentialist categories of difference. The shift from equality to multiple differences is a conversational turn near to closure, but a question is left unanswered: 'Are women a unitary subject or a multiple subject?'

The question illustrates a theoretical stance that privileges both a point of view and a political project of emancipation inscribed in a modernist conception of knowledge. The opposition resides in the debate between a modernist and a postmodernist project, which is not yet near to closure. The questions of who is the female subject and what is a subject revolve around the centrality of language. The use of language by definition involves separation and differentiation, but also power. The relationship between feminism and postmodernism has not been an easy one (Flax 1987; Burman 1990; Hawkesworth 1989) in that the latter has been accused of impeding political action and of leading to relativism in values. Similar difficulties have arisen in OT (Newton 1996: 15) and for similar reasons: 'there is no easy reconciliation between postmodernism and action, whether the action is aimed at changing society or merely one organization. . . . Action inevitably implies choice, and some basis must be found for that choice.' It is evident that the debate is still open in both FT and OT, and it is within this debate that a convergence of interests may appear. The common ground is provided by the sharing of an epistemic culture (Knorr Cetina 1999).

In order to identify a possible convergence of FT and OT, we may look more carefully at their intersections within a postmodern project. Although the many classifications made of the relation between gender and organization overlap according to the criteria used (Alvesson and Billing 1997), agreement exists on the label of 'post-structuralist feminism'. A reason for this unexpected agreement is forthcoming if one looks at methodology. While discussing the existence or otherwise of a feminist methodology, Harding (1987) distinguishes among three methodological positions: gender as a variable (based on positivist assumptions on reality and methodology); a feminist standpoint perspective (theories for women that begin from the experience and point of view of the dominated and point to their capacities, abilities, and strengths); and post-structuralist feminism (critical reflection on how gender is done, order created, and fragmentation suppressed). I am interested in the third methodological position, since it is a reflexive one and therefore allows a meta-theoretical stance on knowledge production practices at the intersection of gender and organization theories.

Leaving the first methodological position aside, the feature that radically distinguishes the women's standpoint from post-structuralist feminism is the conception of 'action', change, or political project. Whilst a modernist project views action as factual change, a postmodernist project sees the 'political' as residing in the destabilization of the categories used to construct scientificity, objectivity, and neutrality. Within a postmodernist project in OT and in FT lies the possibility of articulating reflexivity in the form of answers to the following questions: what do our writings and sayings *do*? To whom do we speak and are accountable? What other voices do we acknowledge, or silence?

Within FT, I have compared these epistemologies elsewhere (Gherardi 1995: 104), describing them as the woman's standpoint approach versus the positionality approach (Table 7.2). The former represents—also in historical and cultural terms—the position in women's studies which gives priority to a point of view situated in women's experiences, while the latter represents gender studies as they have become institutionalized, since the epistemological turn in social studies that problematizes subjectivity, propounds a more sophisticated politics of knowledge, and focuses the researchers' attention on knowledge-producing practices within their disciplines.

The women's standpoint searched for a common denominator and extolled the condition of sameness. By contrast, positionality presupposes a discursive order where gender relations are the outcome of discourse practices; that is, they derive from the way in which people actively produce social and psychological realities. The scientific and political account that sustains positionality is a postmodern project in the sense that it seeks to problematize knowledge, to delegitimize all beliefs concerning truth, power, the self, language, and everything that is taken for granted. Conversely, the inscribing of a female perspective in knowledge, in power, in the truth system, can be called a modernist project that constructs a definitive subjectivity.

Table 7.2 The 'woman's standpoint' approach compared to the 'positionality' approach

Women's standpoint	Versus	Positionality
sees male and female as mutually exclusive		sees male and female as indivisible positions of reciprocal relation
stresses sameness		stresses difference
presupposes a normative order		presupposes a discursive order
recalls a modern project		envisioning a postmodern project
emphasizes subjectivity		deconstructs subjectivity

For Davies and Harré (1990) the concept of positioning belongs to social psychology, and their use of the term 'positioning' contrasts with the concept of human agency as role player. It is therefore useful for analysis of the production of self as a linguistic and relational practice within the dynamic occasions of encounters. It is within a particular discourse that a subject (the position of a subject) is constructed as a compound of knowledge and power into a more or less coercive structure that ties it to an identity. A subject position incorporates both a conceptual repertoire and a location for persons within the structure of the rights pertaining to those who use the repertoire. A position is what is created in and through conversations as speakers and hearers construct themselves as persons. A subject position creates a location in which social relations and actions are mediated by symbolic forms and modes of being.

Davies and Harré employ the concept of positioning to illuminate discursive practices at the level of social interactions, Alcoff (1988) uses it to shed light on a politics of identity understood as the choice from among a plurality of selves and as positionality in a social context. Alcoff proposes a positional definition of woman which 'makes her identity relative to a constantly shifting context, to a situation that includes a network of elements involving others, the objective economic conditions, cultural and political institutions and ideologies, and so on' (Alcoff 1988: 433). And part of my conception of positionality (Gherardi 1995) is the production of the positions of women and men as a discursive and material construction of an interpersonal relation in a multi-faceted public process by which gender meanings are progressively and dynamically achieved, performed, transformed, disseminated, and institutionalized. In sum, bodies and activities are constituted in gendered practices, and this conception of gender bypasses the initial location of difference either in the body, in society, or in language. Gender may be defined as a social accomplishment, learnt and enacted on appropriate occasions and organized around shared practical understanding of its performance.

Positioning gender is an approach that does not seek to posit a subjectivity of women or men in oppositional terms. It is instead an approach that reflects the essential indeterminacy of the symbolic order of gender in situated material-semiotic practices, governed as it is by the endless process of difference and deferral⁴ of the meaning of male and female. Positioning gender introduces a concept of decentred subjectivity in which the subject is open-ended and indeterminate except when it is fixed in place by culturally constituted gender practices. Women and men

⁴ 'Every concept is inscribed in a chain or in a system within which it refers to the other, to other concepts, by means of the systematic play of differences' (Derrida 1982: 11). In coining the term *différance* (with an 'a') Derrida combines the two senses of the French *différer*: to differ in space and to defer in time. Therefore there are two ways of conceiving gender difference: as two separate terms—male and female—and as a process of reciprocal deferral where the presence of one term depends on the absence of the other. But the momentarily suppressed term is waiting to return and stands in a supplementary position to the first.

'do gender' in positioning their subjectivities in situated social practices, and gender as a social practice can be seen as the heterogeneous engineering of bodies, artefacts, discourses, institutions, and organizations (Bruni and Gherardi 2001).

Thus understood, gender studies may be the terrain for convergence and alliance between postmodern organizational studies and post-feminism, in that both pursue a politics of knowledge intended to destabilize logocentric and phallocentric thought. To illustrate what may be the point of confluence, I shall refer to the *Handbook of Organization Studies*, given its symbolic value and the fact that every handbook seeks to shape the development of theory. In the Introduction to the book (Clegg, Hardy, and Nord 1996: 3), the authors draw a significant distinction among organizations as empirical objects, organization as a theoretical discourse, and organizing as a social process. With the latter term the authors 'refer to the embeddedness of organizing within distinct local practices, of language, of culture, of ethnicity, of gender'. A parallel may be drawn with gender studies if the focus of analysis is shifted to women and men as empirical objects identifiable on the basis of biological difference, gender as a theoretical discourse informed by local knowledges, and 'positioning gender' as a social practice which performs gender relations within a network of other social relations and across well-established dichotomies like mind/body, nature/culture, nature/technology, public/private, and many others. Under the umbrella of organizational gender studies three methodological options are present: the study of women and men as empirical referents and gendered individuals, the study of organizational theory as a gendered knowledge practice, and the study of gendering as a reflexive social practice.

Common ground can be found at the intersection of bodies (since knowing is *embodied*), discourses (since language involves power), and practices (as collective accomplishments, materially mediated, of human activities). Looking at the gendering of organization theory and at the organizing of gender practices within organizational settings allows one to reflect on the politics of knowledge that sustain the concepts of 'gender' and 'organization'.

How this convergence has come about can be shown by reviewing the research programmes in organizational gender studies.

7.4 CONFLUENT RESEARCH PROGRAMMES?

A research programme consists of a set of shared problems arranged around a central theoretical core of puzzles elaborated and re-elaborated over time by groups of scholars (Reed 1992). Some research programmes centre on the relationship

between gender and organization, but differ in their identification of core problems.

I have mentioned that an early programme which concentrated on the problem of making women visible. I shall not resume discussion of it here because it represents a stage that many scientific disciplines—including OT—necessarily pass through and which I consider to be only the beginning of the conversation. In OT, as in other disciplines like anthropology, history, philosophy, literature, or education—feminist scholarship has undergone the process described by Du Bois *et al.* (1987): feminist challenges were first levelled at prevailing disciplinary traditions; subsequently, a different scholarship developed from those challenges and suggested different analytical and political perspectives in the discipline.

A second research programme centres around the problem of 'gendering organizational analysis' (Mills and Tancred 1983; Mills 1988) and introduces the category of gender as one of the categories of organizational analysis: gendering occurs through symbols, images, ideologies that legitimate the opportunity structure of organizations. In analogy with the theoretical move from 'organization', as the unit of analysis, to 'organizing' as a boundary-less process, the gendering programme crossed significant boundaries: the public/private divide, the economy and the organization, families and work, emotions and work (Acker 1998).

A third research programme centres on a rereading of the discipline's 'classics', both its founding fathers like Weber (Martin and Knopoff 1997), Mayo and Crozier (Acker and Van Houten 1992), and its mothers like Mary Parker Follet (forum in *Organization*, 1996), and Simone de Beauvoir (forum in *Journal of Management Inquiry* 2000). Calás and Smircich (1992a) use the metaphor of re-visioning the field in order to produce insights that change the ways we think about classic theories and teach them.

I shall not dwell on these programmes because they complement rather than challenge malestream knowledge production practices in organization theory. I concentrate on the emerging and less well-established programmes that may open both gender studies and organizational studies to what Sandra Harding (1996) calls 'cultural cognitive diversity'.

As Judi Marshall (2000) has pointed out, there is a tendency in organizational scholarship to appreciate gender and diversity and to enclose these issues in separate chapters (the reference is to the *Handbook of Organization Studies*, Clegg, Hardy, and Nord 1996), while there is little discussion of them in other chapters: 'such issues are raised but then marginalized by mainly separate consideration' (Marshall 2000: 170). Mainstream conversation in organizational scholarship reflects a continuing marginalization of gender scholarship, and most mainstream scholarship continues to be presented as if theories and data were gender-neutral (Martin 2000). The main reason for such a marginalization may be found in the 'gender = women' equation. But staying at the margins may represent an advantage as well and a respectable knowing standpoint.

For my part I see no need to integrate gender and organization, or to argue that gender is the fundamental organizing principle. While the proponents of integration maintain that organizational studies should incorporate a gender perspective, I prefer to regard FT and OT as independent of each other, interpreting any convergence between the two strands of theorizing as a confluence of interests or a temporary alliance. Consequently, the alliance of gender studies with organization studies may be only tactical for the time being and it maybe realized at the margins of the disciplines where both FT and OT raise the issue of the politics of knowledge.

In the postmodern bricolage of organizational studies there is a book that can be taken as epitomizing the confluence in postmodernist thought between gender and organization. In *Postmodern Management Theory*, Calás and Smircich (1997) collect twenty-two articles representative of Anglo-American literature, distinguishing between a Foucauldian turn (four articles) and a Derridean turn (eight articles). The latter comprise five articles that assume an explicit gender perspective (Martin 1990; Calás and Smircich 1991; Mumby and Putnam 1992; Calás 1993; Fisher and Bristoc 1994). Without wishing to overstate what may only be the result of an idiosyncratic selection, I nevertheless emphasize that many of the articles that have influenced postmodernist thought in organizations combine the gender and deconstructionist approaches. What these two perspectives share is the methodology of deconstructionism and a critique of the social construction of knowledge rooted in the inseparability of power and knowledge. The confluence of OT and FT may be realized on critical examination or re-examination of the role of organization and management theory in relation to social structure in contemporary society.

In post-structuralism and post-structuralist feminism, writing is the metaphor for knowledge, the mode of constructing the 'general text' of our society in which cultural conditions are inscribed via our modes of signification. Thus a number of texts well-known and affirmed in organization theory are rewritten (by inverting oppositional constructions) to reveal their politics by calling attention to strategies of 'truth-making' while leaving the original text 'under erasure' (Spivak 1974). Once these oppositions have been destabilized, it will be impossible to reinscribe them in their original form.

Deconstructionism is an analytic strategy that exposes the manifold ways in which a text can be interpreted. Martin (1990) offers an example of deconstructive methodology within organization studies. Apparently well-intentioned organizational practices may reify rather than alleviate gender inequalities, Martin argues. She recounts the story of a woman for whom the organization arranged a closed-circuit television so that she could watch the launching of a new product while she was in bed recovering from a Caesarean birth, deliberately timed so she could participate in the launching event.

Martin deconstructs this story in order to reveal the suppressed gender conflicts behind the lines of the text. She lists the following nine deconstruction strategies (1990: 349):

- (1) Dismantling a dichotomy, exposing it as a false distinction;
- (2) Examining silences—what is not said;
- (3) Attending to disruptions and contradictions, places where the text fails to make sense;
- (4) Focusing on the element that is most alien to a text or a context as a means of deciphering implicit taboos—the limits to what is conceivable or permissible;
- (5) Interpreting metaphors as a rich source of multiple meanings;
- (6) Analysing ‘double-entendres’ that may point to an unconscious subtext, often sexual in content;
- (7) Separating group-specific and more general sources of bias by ‘reconstructing’ the text with iterative substitution of phrases;
- (8) Exploring, with careful ‘reconstructions’, the unexpected ramifications and inherent limitations of minor policy changes;
- (9) Using the limitations exposed by ‘reconstruction’ to explain the persistence of the *status quo* and the need for more ambitious change programmes.

The rationale for deconstructing organizational texts (such as a narrative or ‘the classics’) is to create marginal textual strategies opening ‘transitional spaces’ (Holvino 1996). An example of a transitional space in Organization Development (OD) is provided by Evangelina Holvino who states that from such a space it is possible to attend to the raced, gendered, and classed subtexts by drawing on the following reading tactics: (1) exploring the symbolic representations of them, (2) identifying the gendered, racialized, and classed identities so created, (3) identifying exclusions of particular subject positions, (4) exploring the rhetorical strategies that inscribe and reproduce current relations of domination in terms of gender, class, racioethnicity. Third World feminism (or post-colonial feminism) not only recognizes differences among women or the intersection of a plurality of differences, but posits the ‘issues of *positionality, difference, and subjectivity* as central to theory production by women of colour’ emphasis in original source. (Holvino 1996: 522, I wish to take her statement further and assume it as central to any theorizing and politics of knowledge.

Deconstruction, post-structuralist, and post-colonial feminisms have helped to shift attention from the subject ‘woman’ to the gender relation, to how this is positioned in and by language, and to the relationship between discourses and institutional forms which create forms of power backed by knowledge claims. This is not to imply that only these approaches have brought about this shift; nor, even less, that they have become a new orthodoxy, or that the only way to produce knowledge is to deconstruct one text after another. On the contrary, what I find so interesting in the passage from modernity to a postmodern culture is the multiplicity of competing voices that create plurality of perspectives and blur boundaries, so that from an assumption of ‘things or persons in themselves’ one passes to reconstruction of things and persons as ‘achievements’ performed

in—and through—sociotechnical relations. In my opinion at least three other streams of research may be considered confluent on a similar agenda: the research programme labelled ‘to name men as men’, cyberfeminism, and ‘positioning gender’ as performativity.

Of particular importance for organizational studies is the programme that has been labelled ‘naming men as men’: an expression that prompted Collinson and Hearn (1994, 1996) to study the contents and forms of men/managerialism (Kerfoot and Whitehead 1998; Kerfoot 1999), to conduct a critique of hegemonic masculinity (Connell 1987, 1995; Kimmel 1987) and compulsive heterosexuality. By interweaving men, masculinities, and management, these authors have sought to ‘break the silence’ (Harlow, Heam, and Parkin 1995) that renders masculinity invisible and removes it from discourse. This silence and expulsion from organizational discourse also concerns organizational sexuality (Hearn and Parkin 1987/1995; Hearn *et al.* 1989) and cathexis (Connell 1995) or sexual desire. In my opinion, the main contribution of these studies to a politics of knowledge in organization theory is the fact that masculinity is also a standpoint claiming to the monopoly of ‘objectivity’ and within masculinity there are a plurality of voices.

Another contribution to a politics of knowledge is the erosion of the divide between nature/society, science/technology, human/non-human, and text and matter. Donna Haraway (1991)—and cyberfeminism with her—invites reconsideration of the politics of positioning as a new epistemology that conducts a critique of classic humanism and invites us to consider the role of ‘high-tech’ in changing the meaning of what is ‘human’ and also of sexual difference. The cyborg metaphor acts on both a material and a textual/mythical level. It is a deconstructive device, proposing a ‘materialized refiguration’ (Haraway 1994: 62); that is, not just to read the webs of knowledge production but to reconfigure what counts as knowledge in the interests of reconstituting the generative forces of embodiment. Cyberfeminism, at the crossroads of science studies, feminist theory, and cultural studies (King 1994), considers technology to be a source of new identities made of rapid connections and dis-connections that transgress the sexual dualism and also the hetero/homosexuality dualism (a queer subject). It posits local but not particularistic, partial but not chaotic, knowledges and resides at the centre of the paradox of postmodern subjectivity in relation to technoscience. The feminist critique of science (and that conducted internally to the sociology of science and technology) has helped to show that even ‘universal’ knowledge is situated, and that feminist objectivity simply means bodily-situated knowledge. The advantage of a ‘partial perspective’—the term is Donna Haraway’s taken up by Marilyn Strathern (1991)—is that knowledge always has to do with circumscribed domains, not with transcendence and the subject/object dichotomy. Strathern’s (1991) term ‘partial connections’ links with the European tradition of the notions of relatedness, connectedness-in-action (Cooper and Fox 1990), or ‘partially connected’

knowledges. Cyberfeminism connects with so-called Actor Network Theory (Law 1999), which basically assumes that technology is society made durable (Latour 1991); identity and social relations should be performed.

A final research programme now consolidating at the confluence between gender and organization centres on the concept of performativity introduced by Judith Butler (1990, 1993, 1999) and subsequently taken up by actor-network theory and by other analyses that problematize professional identities (Dent and Whitehead 2001) or the joint construction of gender and technology within material-semiotics networks. Although this programme has a great deal in common with the previous post-structuralist one, it differs therefrom by not taking the same methodological option and not concentrating principally on discursive practices or text analysis. Instead, it resumes the sociological tradition of symbolic interactionism in the concept of 'doing gender' (West and Zimmerman 1987; Gherardi 1994) and defines gender as situated social practice. Butler (1990: p. xii) proposes 'parodic practices based on a performative theory of gender acts that disrupt the categories of the body, sex, gender and sexuality and occasion their subversive resignification and proliferation beyond the binary frame'. Thus gender (and also organization, as we shall see) is shown to be a performatively enacted signification that 'released from its naturalized interiority and surface can occasion the parodic proliferation and subversive play of gendered meanings' (ibid. 33). Consequently, masculinity, too, can be read as something that men do alone or in the presence of women when they 'mobilize masculinities'. The concept of the masculine subject as a performative accomplishment allows us to see masculinity as a practice and not as an attribute. Patricia Martin (2001) proposes the concept of 'mobilizing masculinities' in interpretation of 'the practices wherein two or more men jointly bring to bear, or bring into play, masculinity/ies'. In mobilizing masculinity/ies at work men may mobilize the material and discursive codes of practice of the profession. The ritualistic repetition of these normalized codes gives materiality to belonging to the community and may explain the persistence of masculinist discourses, jokes, behaviours, styles even in mixed gender practices. The materiality of the social comes into play through the concepts of situated practice and technological artefacts that embody gender concepts. Martin uses the term 'conflation' for the dynamic of fusing masculinities with working processes and she conducts an empirical analysis from the women's standpoint of men's masculinity mobilizing practices. She identifies two substantive categories of masculinities (contesting and affiliating), the audiences for men's mobilizing work (for women, for men, or for both), and the dynamic of conflation (work occasions masculinity/ies). Martin's analysis can be considered part of the research on 'doing gender' which originated in symbolic interactionism, but the concept of mobilizing is also part of the actor-network literature (Callon 1986*a*; 1986*b*).

The notion of mobilization is used in the actor-network literature in its dual political and physical sense: through mobilization (in its political sense) a role and a

recognizable identity are conferred on an actor. The theory extends the meaning of the term as applied to social phenomena (a demonstration, an organized movement) to sociotechnical and material systems (a technical drawing, an estimate, a cheque, a scientific report). I borrow both meanings of mobilization in order to describe the mobilization of gender as a social and material practice, since in interpreting something as gendered 'masculine', the silent term is also present in its absence.

Therefore, if gender is a historical and situated social practice, then it can be 'done' (theorized, practised, narrated) differently, since gender is the effect of 'technologies of gender' (De Lauretis 1996). We settle gender relations amongst the subject positions available to us and produced by existing discourses—we are lived embodiments of discourses—but discourses are historically and temporally located and there are limitless other ways of being, thinking, and doing. Foucault (1986: 46) calls *assujettissement* (subjectification) the process by which we come to know about ourselves and to structure the field of our possibilities: there are limitless other ways of subjectification, of knowing, and of producing knowledge.

If an influence of FT on OT is to be discerned, it is situated in the critique of its power/knowledge regime. In other words, a tactical alliance between FT and OT is possible if it takes the form of a politics of knowledge, which reveals that every attempt to label something as 'knowledge' is embedded in a network of power relations that defines both the subject of such knowledge and its object.

7.5 CONCLUSIONS

Organizational theory, as a body of knowledge about organizations and as a theoretical discourse, has adopted the gender perspective somewhat belatedly compared to other academic disciplines such as history or literature. OT has been more tenacious than other disciplines in defending a 'gender-neutral' position that minimizes gender differences. In OT studies, revision of the 'classics' in order to expose the gender bias that has accompanied the institutionalization of the discipline is still in progress (Martin 2000). Finally, in managerial applications of OT, preoccupation with gender discrimination and integration policies has bred an obsession with inclusion of both women and feminist theory at all costs. In sum OT still segregates the gender approach in separate 'chapters' that reproduce its fundamental 'otherness'.

I believe that the principal reason for this is that organizational gender studies are still identified with studies that start from assumptions of biological difference and

cultural explanations for it. It is important to highlight biological diversity and emphasize that bodies are part of what individuals bring to play in organizations. But it is restrictive to view the body as the origin or cause of gender. There is no simple or linear cause/effect relationship between body and gender; rather, a network of transfers, translations, inferences, and influences constitute gender relations. With an apt expression Teresa De Lauretis (1999) says that the body is not the cause (of gender relations), but rather a symptom. The body is en-gendered by a social, cultural, and organizational process of gender self-attribution. The latter is not a performative process that mobilizes habits, inclinations, displacements, and phantasms and attaches them to a body already endowed with sexuality and sexual gender. Instead, it is a process that simultaneously produces both a body for the subject and a subject for that body. The significance of the body in relation to practices of organization merits closer attention (Melucci 1996; Hassard, Holliday, and Willmott 2000). The gender approach, therefore, although it starts from the centrality of the body, offers an opportunity for mature reflection on the interrelations among subjects, discourses, and situated social practices. It brings a cultural cognitive diversity into the mainstream agenda.

The body as a symptom and not as a cause is an interpretative key that opens the door to critical reflection on the processes of subjectivation, sexualization, and gender attribution as effects of power/knowledge relations within a social field. The gender approach is an opportunity to interrogate and ground a politics of knowledge that reflects on how social practices shape both the knowing subject and the known objects. It is on this terrain that a confluence may arise between postmodern organizational studies aimed at destabilizing the traditional categories of the discipline, and which therefore conduct critical reflection on the subjects and objects of knowledge, and gender studies.

Numerous conversations are possible and legitimate, but the effects that ensue from them may differ greatly in ethical, political, and aesthetic terms. Faced with this awareness, it is possible either to take up the privileged discursive stance of those who adopt a feminist standpoint or to assume the position of the ironic feminist mindful of both the gender and the language trap. Irony is a strategy in the politics of knowledge as well as a philosophical position (Derrida 1971; Rorty 1989; Ferguson 1991). My concern has been to illustrate the pragmatics of irony; that is, the destabilization in gender arrangements that ironic discourse can produce. Irony insinuates doubt. It suggests that the world can be described in different terms, but it does not propose these other terms as alternative, 'better', 'more correct', or 'truer'. Irony is a processual invitation; an invitation to consider how things (gender relationships and organizational relationship) can be redefined; how common sense can be problematized. Irony does not offer solutions; instead, it calls into question the linguistic games that produce a certain vision of the world.

What I find so interesting in the passage from modernity to a postmodern culture is the multiplicity of competing voices which create plurality of perspectives and blur boundaries, so that from an assumption of 'things or persons in themselves' one passes to reconstruction of things and persons as 'achievements' performed in—and through—sociotechnical relations. The concept of agency situated within a posthumanist social theory recognizes from the beginning that the material world (the non-human) and human agency reciprocally constitute one another. Self-definition and the erosion of self-definition is threatening but it is also challenging: the historical deferral of the meaning of gender does not mean the loss of its heuristic value but the questioning of postmodern subjectivities within power/knowledge relationships and situated practices of gendering the human and the non-human.

At the confluence of FT and OT there is the question of how the subject of knowledge is formed and of what metaphor linguistically represents a decentred subject and a protean subjectivity. The metaphors that problematize the relation among subjects, discourses, and social practices within a politics of knowledge can be provided by irony, nomadism, and eccentricity.

The ironist represents the subjectivity of a knowing subject imprisoned by the language that constitutes his/her 'final vocabulary'. His/her politics of knowledge is redescription rather than inference: 'ironists specialize in redescribing ranges of objects or events in partially neologistic jargon. An ironist hopes that by the time she has finished using old words in new senses, not to mention introducing brand-new words, people will no longer ask questions phrased in the old words' (Rorty 1989: 78).

A second metaphor is that of the nomad subject who seeks to evade the trap of fixed and fixated subjectivity. The subject thus defined traces knowledge itineraries through multiple points of intersection: differences between men and women, differences among women, differences within men. There emerges a strengthened difference that evades hegemonic thought. The politics of knowledge that derives therefrom is, in the words of Rosi Braidotti, a set of conceptual trajectories that constitute a plural and open project: a polyphonous game of multiplicity.

Finally, the metaphor of the eccentric subject (de Lauretis 1999) denotes a subject aware of constituting itself in an ever-becoming history, in an interpretation and rewriting of self based on another cognition of society and culture. This subject is eccentric with respect to the social field, to institutional devices, to the symbolic, to language itself. It is a subject that simultaneously responds to and resists the discourses that interpellate it.

An ironic, nomadic, eccentric knowing subject resists integration into mainstream disciplinary knowledge, but not out of a desire not to isolate but to produce knowledge from the margins and retain a meta-theoretical stance on the practices of knowledge production, both in the mainstream and at its margins. Marginal

practices retain the power of undermining local stability and insinuate suspicion in taken-for-granted *habitus*, beliefs, and meanings.

Therefore, a gender perspective within organizational studies that is ironic, nomadic, and eccentric cannot be integrated into the main/malestream, but it can forge tactical alliances with other perspectives critical of the mainstream politics of knowledge and of the social practices sustaining it.

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